party continued to give tickets and whatever else they wanted to these leaders. Rahul and Priyanka campaigned for some of them too. But they spent little time on party work in their constituencies, so they kept losing. How can Rahul be blamed for this?" asks a Lok Sabha MP from the party. While Scindia and Sushmita won the 2014 Lok Sabha poll, they lost in 2019. Prasada, Tanwar and Jitendra Singh have been losing since 2014.

Several Congress leaders even claim that the perception that these leaders were close to Rahul was a "carefully cultivated PR exercise". They were seen moving around with him in Parliament around the same time he became a Lok Sabha member for the first time, and he interacted more with them because they were his contemporaries. "As a leader, Rahul is very affectionate towards his colleagues. Many among us misunderstand it as a passport to get the positions we aspire for. But when it comes to party and organisation, he keeps the larger interest in mind and doesn't practise favouritism. Then the so-called friends get upset and blame him for their inability to deliver," says Lok Sabha MP and Congress CWC member Manickam Tagore.

Besides the shrinking electoral capital, what troubled these former friends was the gradual sidelining within the party organisation. The party's de facto leader apparently also did not intervene to protect their "valid concerns". In 2018, Rahul chose veteran Kamal Nath over Scindia as the chief ministerial choice for Madhya Pradesh. In Uttar Pradesh, Prasada sought to position himself as a Brahmin leader. But when Priyanka Gandhi became general secretary in-charge of UP, he found he had no role in her scheme of things. Former royal and Kurmi leader R.P.N. Singh was involved in a turf war with state Congress president Ajay Kumar Lallu whose assembly constituency Tamkuhi Raj falls within Kushi Nagar, the Lok Sabha constituency RPN contests from. Lallu, incidentally, is a close confidant of Priyanka.

ROLL CALL OF COUNSELLORS

Rahul Gandhi has sought the advice of these leaders at different phases of his political career

DIGVIJAYA SINGH (2007-2012)
The ex-MP CM was seen as Rahul's 'guru'; lost influence after the 2012 UP assembly poll loss

JAIRAM RAMESH (2008-2014)
Still consulted on policy matters but doesn't have the influence he had before 2014

MOHAN PRAKASH (2009-2015)
The Rajasthan socialist was a guide on UP politics; now back as the observer for Uttarakhand polls

C.P. JOSHI (2012-2017)
Key poll strategist. Mishandling of the northeastern states, which he oversaw, cost him proximity to Rahul

MADHUSUDAN MISTRY (2013-'17)
Good at data-crunching but failed to deliver on the ground. Currently head of the party's Central Election Authority

ASHOK GEHLOT (2017-2018)
As organisational secretary, he got close to the Gandhi scion, who picked him as the Rajasthan CM over Sachin Pilot

Tanwar was upset because he was removed as Haryana Congress president in 2019. Rahul also did little to protect him against state satraps such as former chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda, who had allegedly made things difficult for Tanwar. But, as a Congress MP from Haryana asks, "Why does he blame others when he could not win his own seat twice?"

Many within the party admit that Sushmita Dev's departure was necessitated by the changing sociopolitical scenario in Assam's Barak Valley where her constituency, Silchar, falls. The Barak Valley is dominated by Bangla-speaking Hindus and Muslim. Most of the immigrant Hindus support the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, but the Congress is against it. Though Sushmita took a separate stand from the Congress on the issue, this was not enough to convince the Hindu vote bank. Weighing her options, she chose to join the TMC, which is wooing voters as a party for the Bangla-speaking population in Assam, irrespective of their religion.

THE DESERTIONS HAVE NOT AFFECTED THE PARTY MUCH BUT THEY HAVE CAUSED A BIG DENT IN THE POLITICAL BRAND EQUITY OF RAHUL GANDHI

Congress insiders say unlike Scindia, who was instrumental in dethroning the Congress government in MP, the other turncoats will not cause any significant damage to the party. Scindia and Sushmita have taken the Rajya Sabha route to Parliament while Prasada entered the upper house of the UP legislature. RPN and Tanwar are still undecided on their future course of action. But the desertions have caused a big dent in the political brand equity of Rahul Gandhi as these leaders were perceived to be close to him.

The redemption will now depend on his latest gamble—selecting Charanjit Singh Channi as the Congress CM candidate for Punjab and ignoring the mercurial Navjot Singh Sidhu. Just months ago, Sidhu was the chosen soldier of Rahul and Priyanka in their plan to neutralise former chief minister Amarinder Singh. The results of the Punjab assembly election will determine whether this new move was a masterstroke or another dud by the perennial prince of the party. ■